

Confucianism



Kong Fuzi, known in the West as Confucius, was of the generation following Laozi, and may have consulted him in his capacity as court archivist. While Laozi had outlined a moral philosophy, Confucius was concerned with providing a political structure that would allow a stable but just government. This, he argued, should be based on virtue and benevolence but, contrary to conventional belief, he thought moral goodness was not god-given, nor restricted to any particular social class. Instead, he believed that virtue could be cultivated, and that it was the ruling class's role to lead by example. The *junzi*, or 'superior man', by

making his virtue manifest, would inspire virtue in others, which could be reinforced by ceremony, ritual and social niceties. This could best be achieved by a hierarchical society in which faithfulness was the guiding principle: a ruler should be benevolent, and in return his subjects would show loyalty. Confucius extended this reciprocal faithfulness to other relationships – between loving parent and obedient child, husband and wife, siblings, and friends and colleagues.